

THE TEXTOLOGICAL STATUS OF THE QUR'ĀN SELF-REFERENTIAL INDICATIONS AS A CRITERION FOR IDENTIFYING THE AUTHENTIC MUṢḤAF

Monograph

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Field:

Quranic Studies

Textology

Semitic philology

Astana, Kazakhstan

2026

PUBLICATION DATA

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ABSTRACT

This monograph proposes a methodologically novel approach to the problem of dating the Quranic text. In contrast to traditional external dating methods (radiocarbon analysis, palaeography), the study draws on the self-referential indications of the Qur'ān — descriptions of the physical characteristics of the Scripture contained within the text itself.

The central thesis: the text of the Qur'ān contains descriptions of the physical muṣḥaf as an already existing object, which demonstrates its fixation during the period of the text's formation. Grammatical analysis shows that all indications employ forms of completed action or the present tense, not the future.

Linguistic analysis of the term سَفَرَة (80:15), traditionally interpreted as "angels", reveals the meaning "scribes" on the basis of a Semitic parallel with the Hebrew סֹפֵר (sofer) and contextual analysis.

On the basis of the identified criteria, an analysis of 21 surviving muṣḥafs has been conducted. The Al-Ḥusayn Muṣḥaf (Cairo, inv. no. 139) has been identified as the earliest of the complete muṣḥafs on the basis of a combination of antiquity markers: scriptio continua, absence of vocalisation, absence of ornamentation.

Keywords: the Qur'ān, muṣḥaf, textology, palaeography, self-referential indications, scriptio continua, سفرة, lifetime fixation, codicology, Semitic philology.

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INTRODUCTION

The Dating Problem

The question of the time of fixation of the Quranic text remains contested in academic scholarship. Traditional Islamic historiography holds that the Qur'ān was compiled into a single codex after the death of the Prophet Muḥammad — initially under Caliph Abū Bakr (d. 13/634), then standardised under Caliph 'Uthmān (d. 35/656).

This tradition is based on external sources — ḥadīths and historical chronicles compiled centuries after the events they describe. The dating methods employed address different tasks and do not directly establish the moment of the text's inscription:

— Palaeography establishes the relative chronology of scribal traditions, not the moment of composition of a specific manuscript. The anchor points (the Namāra inscription of 328, Zabad 512, Harrān 568) are epigraphic, lapidary, non-Quranic and non-manuscript — transferring their graphic features to the manuscript tradition is an assumption, not a proof. Palaeography dates the type of script, not the act of writing the text.

— Radiocarbon analysis (C14) dates the moment of death of the animal whose skin was used for parchment. It does not date the processing of the material, the manufacture of the leaf, or the moment of writing. The practice of storing parchment before use is documented in papyrology and codicology. The margin of error of ± 30 –50 years makes C14 unsuitable for distinguishing lifetime fixation from 'Uthmānic standardisation. The Birmingham fragment is a telling example: its dating range overlaps both periods simultaneously. C14 dates the writing support, not the act of writing.

— The ḥadīth tradition is recorded in the late 2nd–3rd centuries AH. Isnāds have no independent external verification and are not corroborated by contemporary documents. Ḥadīths are a historico-literary source recording the community's historical memory, but do not serve as an independent dating instrument.

Possible objection: in academic practice methods are applied in combination — "convergence of data" strengthens the conclusion. This is true for the tasks the methods collectively address. However, the convergence of three indirect methods does not create a direct dating instrument: the sum of indirect evidence remains indirect. None of the three methods — individually or collectively — directly establishes the moment of the text's inscription. It is precisely this task that the present study addresses.

Methodological Novelty

The present study proposes an alternative approach: the use of self-referential indications — descriptions of the physical muṣḥaf contained within the text of the Qur'ān itself.

Methodological advantage: this approach does not require recourse to external sources whose reliability is itself a matter of dispute. The proof rests exclusively on the analysis of the text and Arabic grammar.

Key assumption: the study treats the text of the Qur'ān as a historical document, without addressing questions of its origin. The question "who is the author of the text" is not considered. The question addressed is: "when was the text committed to writing".

Positioning in the Historiography

The approaches in academic Quranic studies closest to the one proposed here are associated with A. Neuwirth, N. Sinai, and G. Dye. Neuwirth in a series of works on the structural composition of the Qur'ān («Der Koran als Text der Spätantike», 2010) analyses textual markers of written organisation — repetitions, refrains, and symmetrical constructions. Sinai («The Quran: A Historical-Critical Introduction», Edinburgh University Press, 2017) treats the internal evidence of the text as a source for chronological reconstruction, drawing on lexical and genre markers. Dye («Pourquoi et comment se fait un texte canonique?», 2015) investigates the mechanisms of canonical text formation through the analysis of its self-descriptions.

The principal difference between the present study and the works listed above is as follows. Neuwirth, Sinai, and Dye use the internal markers of the text to reconstruct its literary history or genre classification, but not to date its physical fixation. Neuwirth («Der Koran als Text der Spätantike», 2010) analyses structural and compositional markers — repetitions, refrains, symmetry — to establish literary genres and intertextual connections; the question of the moment of transition from oral to written form lies outside the scope of her method. Sinai («The Quran: A Historical-Critical Introduction», 2017) uses lexical and genre markers for the chronological reconstruction of the sequence of revelations, but proceeds from the assumption of the gradual formation of the corpus, not treating self-referential indications of the material muṣḥaf as a dating instrument. Dye (2015) investigates the mechanisms of canonisation through the text's self-descriptions, but does not distinguish descriptions of the heavenly archetype from those of the earthly muṣḥaf as methodologically significant for dating. Self-referential indications of a specific material object — parchment (رَقٍّ), scrolls (مُحْفٍ), scribes (سَفَرَةٍ) — are not identified as an independent chronological criterion in their approaches and are not systematically developed. It is precisely this unoccupied methodological area that the present monograph develops.

Structure of the Study

Chapter 1 analyses the Quranic indications of the physical muṣḥaf: direct descriptions, writing terminology, and linguistic analysis of key terms.

Chapter 2 formalises the logic of the argument and refutes alternative interpretations.

Chapter 3 applies the identified criteria to surviving muṣḥafs and identifies the earliest.

Chapter 4 considers possible objections and provides a defence.

CHAPTER 1. QURANIC FEATURES OF THE MUṢḤAF

1.1. Direct Indications of a Physical Muṣḥaf

1.1.1. Sura 52:1–3

وَالطُّورِ ﴿١﴾ وَكِتَابٍ مَّسْطُورٍ ﴿٢﴾ فِي رَقٍّ مَّنْشُورٍ ﴿٣﴾

"By the Mountain, and by a Scripture inscribed on parchment unrolled"

Grammatical analysis:

Table 1. Grammatical analysis of Sura 52:1–3

Term	Analysis
كِتَابٍ	Book/Scripture — denotes a single completed corpus of text
مَسْطُورٍ	Passive participle (ism maf'ūl) from ر-ط-س «to write in lines». Form مَسْطُورًا denotes completed state: "already inscribed". Not يُسَطَّرُ (future) and not يُسَطَّرُ (process) Possible objection: the participle مَسْطُور may be read normatively — "that which is to be inscribed". This objection is refuted by the syntactic context: وَكِتَابٍ مَسْطُورٍ occurs in the oath construction where an oath presupposes a genuinely existing object. A normative reading would require a different construction — e.g. يَنْبَغِي أَنْ يُسَطَّرَ. The form مَفْعُول in Quranic oath contexts invariably describes the present state of the oath-object.
رَقٍّ	Parchment — tanned skin of an animal. Lane: «a piece of skin... for writing upon». indicates earthly material, not the heavenly archetype. In heavenly contexts the Qur'ān uses لَوْح (tablet), not رَقٍّ
مَنْشُورٍ	Passive participle from ر-ش-ن «to unfold». indicates the format of a codex (مُصْنَف), not a scroll (تَرْج). A codex is unfolded; a scroll is unrolled

Critical point: term رَقٍّ (parchment) is never used in the Qur'ān to describe heavenly realities. For the heavenly archetype لَوْح (85:22). The use of رَقٍّ indicates an earthly, physical object.

1.1.2. Sura 80:11–16

كَلَّا إِنَّهَا تَذْكِرَةٌ (١١) فَمَنْ شَاءَ ذَكَرْهُ (١٢) فِي صُحُفٍ مُكَرَّمَةٍ (١٣) مَرْفُوعَةٍ مُطَهَّرَةٍ (١٤) بِأَيْدِي سَفَرَةٍ (١٥) كِرَامٍ بَرَرَةٍ (١٦)

"Nay! Indeed it is a reminder, so whoever wills may remember it, in honoured scrolls, exalted and purified, by the hands of scribes honoured and righteous!"

Grammatical analysis:

Table 2. Grammatical analysis of Sura 80:11–16

Term	Analysis
صُحُفٍ	Plural of صَحِيفَةٌ «scroll, page, leaf». Lane: «a piece of paper or skin... written upon». indicates a plurality of leaves — a corpus of text
بِأَيْدِي	«By hands» — preposition بِ (instrumental) + أَيْدِي (pl. of يَد «hand»). indicates a physical act — an action performed by hands
سَفَرَةٍ	Plural of سَافِر. Full analysis in section 1.3

Additional argument: the epithets مَرْفُوعَةٍ "exalted" and مُطَهَّرَةٍ "purified" in 80:13–14 do not indicate the heavenly status of the object. مَرْفُوعَةٌ means "honoured" in the sense of dignity, not spatial elevation. مُطَهَّرَةٌ means "ritually pure": the same epithet is applied to humans — الْمُطَهَّرُونَ in 56:79. The epithets characterise the degree of reverence accorded to an earthly object, not its heavenly nature.

Critical point: indication بِأَيْدِي "by hands" presupposes a physical act. If the passage referred to the transmission of revelation by angels, a different construction would be used (لِسَانٍ عَلَى) "upon the tongue", as in 26:193 (قُلُوبُكَ عَلَى الْأَمِينِ الرُّوحُ بِهِ نَزَّلَ).

1.1.3. Sura 98:2

رَسُولٌ مِّنَ اللَّهِ يَتْلُو صُحُفًا مُّطَهَّرَةً

"A Messenger from God reciting purified scrolls"

Grammatical analysis:

Table 3. Grammatical analysis of Sura 98:2

Term	Analysis
يَتْلُو	The verb present tense (مُضَارِع) from «to read aloud, to recite». Form يَفْعُلُ indicates an action occurring at the moment of utterance or habitually
صُحُفًا	Accusative case (بِه مَفْعُول) — direct object. The Messenger reads the scrolls as an object

Critical point: verb يَتْلُو in the present tense indicates that the scrolls already exist at the moment of recitation. If the scrolls were a future project, the form سَيَتْلُو or لَيَتْلُو.

1.1.4. Sura 6:7

وَلَوْ نَزَّلْنَاهُ عَلَيْكَ كِتَابًا فِي قِرْطَاسٍ فَلَمَسُوهُ بِأَيْدِيهِمْ

"And if We had sent down to you a Scripture on parchment and they touched it with their hands"

Term قِرْطَاس (qirtās) — borrowing from Greek χαρτης «papyrus, writing material». Lane: «paper; or a piece of paper... or of skin». indicates a physical writing support.

Critical point: the verse describes a hypothetical situation ("if We had"), but the very framing presupposes that writing on a physical support is a familiar and expected form.

1.1.5. The Distinction between the Earthly and the Heavenly

The Qur'ān consistently distinguishes terminology for earthly and heavenly realities:

Table 4. Distinction between the earthly and the heavenly

Context	Term	Verses
Heavenly archetype	لَوْح (tablet)	85:22
Heavenly archetype	كِتَاب مَكْنُون (hidden book)	56:78
Heavenly archetype	أُمُّ الْكِتَاب (Mother of the Book)	43:4
Earthly muṣḥaf	رَقّ (parchment)	52:3
Earthly muṣḥaf	قِرْطَاس (writing material)	6:7, 6:91
Earthly muṣḥaf	صُحُف (scrolls)	80:13, 98:2

Conclusion: the use of the terms رَقّ, قِرْطَاس, صُحُف indicates an earthly context, not a heavenly one.

1.2. Writing Terminology in the Qur'ān

The Qur'ān contains a developed terminology of written culture:

Table 5. Writing terminology in the Qur'ān

Term	Meaning	Frequency	Verse	Source
كِتَاب	book, scripture	255	2:2	Lane I:2590
صُحُف	scrolls, pages	8	80:13	Lane IV:1651
قَلَم	pen, qalam	4	68:1	Lane VII:2995
سَطَرَ	to write in lines	2	52:2	Lane IV:1320
رَقّ	parchment	1	52:3	Lane III:1134
قِرْطَاس	papyrus, writing material	2	6:7	Lane VII:2408
لَوْح	tablet, board	4	85:22	Lane VII:2677
مِدَاد	ink	2	18:109	Lane VIII:3015

1.2.1. The Oath by the Pen (68:1)

ن وَالْقَلَمِ وَمَا يَسْطُرُونَ

"Nūn. By the pen and what they inscribe!"

Grammatical analysis:

Table 6. Grammatical analysis of Sura 68:1

Term	Analysis
الْقَلَمِ	Definite article ال + قَلَم «pen». The article indicates a specific, known object — the pen as a writing instrument
يَسْطُرُونَ	Present-tense verb, 3rd plural, from ر-ط-س «to write in lines». Form يَفْعُلُونَ indicates an action occurring at the moment of utterance. Subject — plural: a group of writers

Critical point: the oath by the pen and the process of writing at the opening of the sura attests to the significance of written fixation at the moment of utterance. An oath is meaningless if its object does not exist. This is verified by the entire corpus of oath passages in the Qur'ān: oaths by the mountain (52:1), the sun (91:1), the night (91:4), the fig-tree (95:1), the city (90:1) — always by objects of real existence at the moment of speech. The Qur'ān does not swear by non-existent, future, or hypothetical objects. Accordingly, the genre-character of the oath passage does not weaken but reinforces the argument: قَلَم (pen) in 68:1 is introduced into the oath precisely because it genuinely exists at the moment of utterance.

1.2.2. Corpus Analysis: Absence of Metaphorical Use of Support Terms

Possible objection: the terms قُرْطَاس, صُحُف, رَق may be used metaphorically in religious literature. To address this, the full corpus of occurrences of all three terms in the Qur'ān is presented below with analysis of the context of each instance.

Table 7. Corpus analysis of support terms

Term	Verse	Context use	Type of use
رَق	52:3	"In parchment unrolled" — oath passage, spatial construction فِي رَقٍ مَّنْشُورٍ	Physical object
صُحُف	80:13	"In honoured scrolls" — scrolls in the hands of scribes; construction فِي صُحُفٍ مَّكَرَّمَةٍ with preposition of physical containment	Physical object
صُحُف	98:2	"A Messenger from God reciting purified scrolls" — صُحُفًا مُّطَهَّرَةً as the direct object of يَتْلُو "to recite"	Physical object
صُحُف	87:18–19	"The first scrolls — the scrolls of Ibrāhīm and Mūsā" — صُحُفِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَمُوسَى; known written corpora of the prophets	Physical object
صُحُف	53:36, 20:133, 21:104	References to written corpora of previous prophets — in all cases written books, not metaphors	Physical object
قُرْطَاس	6:7	"If We had sent down to you a Scripture on a written leaf" — قُرْطَاس as a physical support that can be touched by hands (فَلَمَسُوهُ بِأَيْدِيهِمْ)	Physical object

Conclusion: none of the 9 occurrences of the three terms in the Qur'ān is metaphorical. In every case: physical objects — parchment with spatial localisation (فِي), scrolls as direct objects of verbs of reading and holding, writing material admitting tactile contact. The terms form a terminologically stable group of material writing supports without figurative use.

1.3. Linguistic analysis of the term سَفَرَة

Traditional Interpretation

The majority of mufasssirūn interpret سَفَرَة (80:15) as "angels":

— Ibn 'Abbās (d. 68/688 AH): "angels" (الملائكة)

- Mujāhid (d. 104/722 AH): "angels" (الملائكة)
 — Qatāda (d. 118/736 AH): "angels mediating between God and His creation" (سفراء الملائكة)
 خلقه وبين بينه الله

Basis: the context "exalted, purified" (مُطَهَّرَةٌ مَرْفُوعَةٌ) is associated with the heavenly.

Linguistic Analysis

The root ر-ف-س in the Arabic language:

Table 8. Root ر-ف-س: forms and meanings

Form	Meaning and source
سَفَرٌ	"to uncover, lay open, disclose" (Lane IV:1370: «he uncovered, laid open, disclosed»)
سِفْرٌ	"book, large volume" (Lane IV:1370: «a book, or writing... especially a large book»). Pl. أَسْفَارٌ
سَافِرٌ	"open; one who discloses/writes" (Lane IV:1371)
سَفَرَةٌ	plural of سَافِرٌ (Lane IV:1371)
سَفِيرٌ	"envoy, intermediary" (Lane IV:1371)

Quranic Use of the Root ر-ف-س

مَثَلُ الَّذِينَ مَلَوا التَّوْرَةَ ثُمَّ لَمْ يَحْمِلُوهَا كَمَثَلِ الْجَمَارِ يَحْمِلُ أَسْفَارًا

"The likeness of those who were entrusted with the Torah and then did not carry it is as the likeness of a donkey carrying books" (62:5)

The Qur'ān uses أَسْفَارٌ (pl. of سِفْرٌ) to denote physical books — volumes of the Torah. The root ر-ف-س in the Qur'ān is associated with writing.

Semitic Parallels

Table 9. Semitic parallels of the term سَفَرَةٌ

Language	Word	Meaning and source
Hebrew	סֹפֵר (sofer)	"scribe" (HALOT: «secretary, scribe»)
Aramaic	סַפְרָא (safra)	"scribe" (Jastrow: «scribe, scholar»)
Akkadian	šāpiru	"scribe, administrator" (CAD Š/1:456)
Arabic	سَافِرٌ / سَفَرَةٌ	"scribe" (proposed)

Hebrew סֹפֵר (sofer) — professional scribe sacred texts. Term סֹפֵרִים denotes a professional scribe of Torah, tefillin, and mezuzot. Arabic سَفَرَةٌ — Semitic cognate Hebrew סֹפֵרִים (sofrim, plural of sofer).

Arguments against the interpretation "angels"

Table 10. Arguments against the interpretation "angels"

Issue	Explanation
بِأَيْدِي (by hands)	The transmission of revelation by angels is described differently: "upon your heart" (26:194), not "by hands". Angel Jibrīl transmits revelation orally (وَقَالَ), he does not write with hands
صُحُف (scrolls)	Term صُحُف denotes physical scrolls. For the heavenly archetype, لَوْح (85:22) or مَكْنُونٌ كِتَاب (56:78)
Context 80:1-10	The sura opens with an address to the Prophet about a blind man (الْأَعْمَى جَاءَهُ أَنْ وَتَوَلَّى عَيْسَى) — an earthly context, not a heavenly one
The root ر-ف-س	In the Qur'ān associated with books (أَسْفَار in 62:5), not with angels. For angels, different terms are used: رُوح, رُسُل, ملائكة
Semitic Parallels	Cognates in Hebrew (סֹפֵר), Aramaic (סַפְרָא), Akkadian (šāpiru) mean "scribe", not "angel"

كَرَامَ بَرَّةٍ	"Honoured and righteous" — epithets applicable to humans. Cf. 80:16 with 82:11 كَرَامًا "honoured scribes" (of recording angels) — there كَاتِبِينَ, not سَفَرَةَ
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Conclusion

سَفَرَةَ = scribes (كُتَّاب). Interpretation "angels" — later, based on the association of the epithets "exalted, purified" with the heavenly, but contradicts:

- linguistics root ر-س-□;
- the Semitic parallels;
- the context of the sura;
- Quranic usage.

Verse 80:15 describes the scrolls of the Qur'ān as being "in the hands of honoured, righteous scribes".

Refutation of the Third Version: سَفَرَةَ as "Envoys"

Besides the traditional interpretation "angels", in academic literature a third version is documented: سَفَرَةَ as "envoys" or "intermediaries" — from سَفِير (safīr) meaning "mediator between two parties". Witztum («The Syriac Milieu of the Quran», Princeton, 2011, p. 87) points to Syriac sāpērā as a possible source of borrowing, combining the functions of "copyist" and "transmitter". This version requires special consideration.

The "envoys" version is refuted by a morphological argument: the word سَفِير forms the plural سَفَرَاء (sufarā') by the pattern فُعَلَاء, and not سَفَرَةَ. The form سَفَرَةَ is the plural of سَافِر by the pattern فَعْلَةٌ — standard for agent nouns (Lane IV:1371). This distinction is not arbitrary: in 82:11 the Qur'ān applies كَرَامًا كَاتِبِينَ "honoured scribes" specifically to recording angels. If سَفَرَةَ in 80:15 denoted angels with a scribal function, the same lexeme كَاتِب would be expected, not سَفَرَةَ. Different terminology for an identical function within one book indicates different referents: كَاتِب = angel registering deeds, سَفَرَةَ = human scribe. As for Syriac sāpērā, it combines the meanings "scribe" and "scholar", which confirms rather than refutes the interpretation "scribes": Arabic سَفَرَةَ preserves precisely the scribal-literary component, reflected also in سِفْر "large book" and أَصْفَار «volumes» (62:5). Additional counter-argument against the "envoys" version: even if the borrowing from Syriac sāpērā is accepted, the semantics of "envoy" does not arise — Syriac sāpērā means "scribe / scholar", not "intermediary" in the sense of سَفِير. The function of transmission (safīr) and the function of writing (sāpērā) are distinct in Semitic languages and expressed by different roots.

1.4. The Opponents' Accusations as Evidence

The Qur'ān records the accusations of opponents, which indirectly attest to the existence of a written text.

1.4.1. Sura 25:5

وَقَالُوا أَأَسَاطِيرُ الْأَوَّلِينَ اكْتَتَبَهَا فَهِيَ تُمْلَى عَلَيْهِ بُكْرَةً وَأَصِيلًا

"And they said: Legends of the ancients! He had them written down and they are dictated to him morning and evening!"

Grammatical analysis:

Table 11. Grammatical analysis of Sura 25:5

Term	Analysis
اِكْتَتَبَهَا	VIII stem (اَفْتَعَلَ) from □-ت-□. Past tense (ماضٍ). VIII stem has a reflexive meaning: "had it written for himself". Lane: "he wrote it, or transcribed it, for himself". The opponents assert: he has already copied it (completed action)
تُمْلَى	Passive voice (مَجْهُول), present tense from م-ل-و/م-ل-م «to dictate». Lane: «it is dictated to him». Action is ongoing
بُكْرَةً وَأَصِيلًا	"Morning and evening" — regularity. Indicates a systematic process of dictation and writing

Critical point: verb اَكْتَتَبَ "had written" presupposes the existence of a written source and a written result. If the Qur'ān was transmitted only orally, the accusation of "copying" would be meaningless. The opponents saw written text.

Methodological clarification. This argument must be qualified precisely: it concerns an accusation whose truth the Qur'ān refutes in the following verse (25:6: قُلْ أَنزَلَهُ الَّذِي يَعْلَمُ السِّرَّ: "Say: it was sent down by the One Who knows the secret"). This means that 25:5 cannot serve as proof that the Qur'ān was actually copied from external sources. It does, however, prove something different: written form of the text was *observable* opponents during the period of the text's formation. The accusation of "copying" presupposes that the opponents could see a written object — otherwise the accusation would have lacked plausibility as a rhetorical device. Thus 25:5 proves not the origin of the text but the existence of a written muṣḥaf in a polemical context.

1.4.2. Sura 16:103

وَلَقَدْ نَعْلَمُ أَنَّهُمْ يَقُولُونَ إِنَّمَا يُعَلِّمُهُ بَشَرٌ

"And indeed We know that they say: It is only a human being who teaches him!"

The accusation presupposes a source of information. Together with 25:5 (اَكْتَتَبَهَا "had written") this points to a written source.

1.4.3. Etymology أساطير

Term أساطير (pl. of أُسْطُورَة) in 25:5 and 68:15 is etymologically associated with writing:

- The root ر-ط-س means «to write in lines» (Lane IV:1320).
- أُسْطُورَة — «written history, legend» (Lane IV:1321: «a written legend»).
- The accusation of transmitting أساطير presupposes written sources.

1.4.4. The Polemic as Social Evidence of Lifetime Writing

Verse 25:5 contains three independent elements whose combination constitutes social evidence of the lifetime written fixation of revelations. First: verb اَكْتَتَبَهَا — "had them written / copied" — denotes not oral borrowing but a specific act of written fixation. Second: construction فَهِيَ تُثْلَى عَلَيْهِ — "they are dictated to him" — describes the process of dictation as a current practice. Third: the polemic is conducted in the present tense, presupposing that the object being discussed exists at the moment of dispute.

Key argument: if the text were compiled posthumously by editors, the reproduction of a live dispute about what is happening "now" would serve no communicative function. A living polemical text functions only in the context for which it was created. Accordingly, 25:5 dates not the manuscript but the communicative situation: the practice of written fixation of revelations was an observable reality for contemporaries and a subject of public debate during the Prophet's lifetime.

1.5. Structural Features of Written Fixation

Table 12. Structural features of written fixation

Feature	Indication of written fixation
Basmala as a divider	The formula بِسْمِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ at the beginning of 113 of 114 suras — a structural element functioning as a divider. an oral tradition does not require a uniform divider
Order of suras	The order of suras in the muṣḥaf is neither chronological nor thematic. Such organisation requires editorial work with a written text
Cross-references	Thematic connections between suras (e.g., the story of Mūsā across different suras) presuppose work with a unified corpus of text
Division into verses	Numbering and division into verses — a feature of a structured written text

Important clarification. The structural features listed above may be interpreted as evidence of editorial work, but do not necessarily prove written fixation as such: scholars of the oral poetic tradition (W. Graham, «Beyond the Written Word», 1987; A. Neuwirth, «Studien zur Komposition der mekkanischen Suren», 1981) point out that analogous structural organisation is achieved in developed oral traditions through mnemotechnics and oral redaction. Nevertheless, structural arguments acquire complete probative force *in combination* with the material indications of sections 1.1–1.3: the terminology رَقٍّ, صُحُفٍ, قُرْطَاسٍ denotes specific physical objects that cannot be reinterpreted in oral-compositional terms. No oral tradition swears by parchment (52:3) or points to scribes working with their hands (80:15) — these indications presuppose a present physical object, regardless of the structural features of the text.

1.6. The Single Act of Revelation: A Corpus of Intra-Textual Witnesses

The thesis of lifetime written fixation rests on intra-textual evidence of a single act of the revelation of the corpus. Three independent verses describe the Qur'ān as a single object (الْقُرْآنُ / هُ), revealed in a single moment. 2:185: شَهْرُ رَمَضَانَ الَّذِي أُنْزِلَ فِيهِ الْقُرْآنُ — verb أُنْزِلَ in the singular, in a completed form, specific time period. 44:2-3: إِنَّا أَنْزَلْنَاهُ فِي لَيْلَةِ مُبَارَكَةٍ — pronoun هُ denotes the entire corpus as a single object. 97:1: إِنَّا أَنْزَلْنَاهُ فِي لَيْلَةِ الْقَدْرِ — the same construction, single object, single moment.

Verse 17:105–106 distinguishes two fundamentally different actions. بِالْحَقِّ أَنْزَلْنَاهُ وَبِالْحَقِّ نَزَلَ — a single completed act of revelation. وَفَرَأَيْنَا فَتَفَرَّقَنَاهُ لِتَفْرَأَهُ عَلَى النَّاسِ عَلَى مُخْتٍ — division for subsequent gradual recitation to people, not the structure of the corpus at the time of revelation. Gradual recitation presupposes an existing complete corpus: one cannot recite in parts what does not yet exist as a whole. Verse 75:17: إِنَّ عَلَيْنَا جَمْعَهُ — "upon Us is its gathering" — declares جمع (assembly into a single corpus) is the prerogative of the source of revelation, directly excluding posthumous compilation by humans.

Verse 15:87 — "We have given you seven oft-repeated ones and the great Verbal Corpus" — is an intra-textual self-description of the structure of the corpus as a whole, including the preface (first sura) and the main body. The text knows its own architecture as completed. Verses 15:90–93 censure those who divided the Verbal Corpus: الَّذِينَ جَعَلُوا الْقُرْآنَ عِضِينَ — this is an internal prohibition on further division of the already existing unified corpus.

1.7. Structural Self-Reference as a System

The self-referential elements examined in sections 1.1–1.4 form a closed three-level system. Level one — the writing support: specific material objects without metaphorical use in the Qur'ān: (6:7) قُرْطَاسٍ, (98:2, 80:13) صُحُفٍ, (52:3) رَقٍّ. Level two — the act of writing: description of the mechanism of writing as an ongoing process: (25:5) اُكْتُتِبَ, (68:1) يَسْطُرُونَ, (68:1) الْقَلَمُ (80:15). Level three — the completed corpus: description of the state of a finished object, not an action: (80:13) كِتَابٍ مَسْطُورٍ, (52:2) فِي رَقٍّ مَنشُورٍ, (52:3) صُحُفٍ مُكَرَّمَةٍ.

Methodological significance of the system: the text simultaneously describes the material on which it is written, the process of its own writing, and its state as a completed corpus. Such a closed system is possible only from within a writing culture in which the written form of the text is part of reality at the moment of its creation. The three levels are distributed across different suras of different genres — their simultaneous presence is systemic, not coincidental. Methodologically, systemicity is defined not by the presence of syntactic connections between verses but by the convergence of independent witnesses towards a single conclusion — this is the standard principle of convergent evidence in historical linguistics and textology: several independent classes of witnesses pointing in one direction form a more reliable foundation than any one of them alone. To refute the structural self-reference as a system, one would need to prove that all three levels arose independently and coincidentally — which requires positive evidence that does not exist.

Term كِتَابٍ مَسْطُورٍ in 52:2 is a passive participle from سَطَرَ — "to write in lines" — and denotes the completed state of the object, not a process. The combination with فِي رَقٍّ مَنشُورٍ — "in parchment unrolled" — indicates a publicly accessible completed physical object, and not

individual fragments. The oath (52:1-4) brings together a physical mountain, a physical written object, and a physically visited house: three genuinely existing objects in one enumeration.

1.8. Summary Table of Quranic Features

Table 13. Summary table of Quranic features

Category	Features	Verses
Direct indications	Scripture inscribed, parchment, scrolls	52:1-3, 80:13-16, 98:2
Terminology	كتاب، صحف، قلم، سطر، رق، قرطاس، لوح، مداد	Numerous
Oath by the pen	Pen and the process of writing	68:1, 96:4
Accusations	"Copied", "a human being teaches him"	25:5, 16:103
Scribes	سَفَرَة — scribes	80:15
Earthly materials	رق (parchment), قرطاس (papyrus)	52:3, 6:7

Overall conclusion Chapter 1. The analysis of sections 1.1–1.8 demonstrates that the self-reference of the Qur'ān constitutes not a set of scattered observations but a systemic phenomenon. The text contains a terminologically stable group of material writing supports without metaphorical use (1.1–1.2); an indication of scribes working with their hands (1.3); a polemical witness dating the communicative situation (1.4); structural features of a written corpus (1.5); intra-textual evidence of a single act of revelation (1.6); and a closed three-level system of self-reference (1.7). Six independent classes of arguments, distributed across different suras of different genres, converge towards a single conclusion: the muṣḥaf as a physical object existed during the period of the text's formation. None of the six classes is individually necessary and sufficient; their combination forms a body of evidence whose refutation would require the simultaneous destruction of all six independent arguments.

CHAPTER 2. THE LOGIC OF THE ARGUMENT

2.1. Methodological Foundations

The study treats the text of the Qur'ān as a historical document. The following methodological foundations are adopted:

1. The text of the Qur'ān exists. This is an empirical fact requiring no proof.
2. The text contains descriptions of physical objects (scrolls, parchment, pen, ink).
3. The grammatical forms of Arabic are amenable to objective analysis.
4. Semitic languages exhibit regular lexical correspondences.

Not adopted and not required:

- The question of the origin of the text (divine, human, or other).
- The question of authorship (who specifically spoke or wrote the text).
- Traditional reports (ḥadīths, sīra), whose reliability is not independently verifiable.

2.1.1. Self-Reference as an Independent Criterion: Establishing Reliability

The possible objection to using self-referential indications as a chronological criterion is as follows: a later editor could have inserted descriptions of the muṣḥaf retrospectively, i.e. after the physical fixation of the text. If so, the self-reference would indicate not the period of formation but the period of redaction, remaining useless for dating.

This objection is refuted by three independent arguments.

Argument 1: dispersal of self-referential indications. The self-reference is distributed across independent suras of different genres and chronological layers: an oath formula (68:1 — early Meccan), a narrative (80:13–16 — middle Meccan), polemic (25:5 — middle Meccan), a descriptive passage (52:2–3 — late Meccan), a statement (98:2 — Medinan). Retrospective

redaction encompassing such heterogeneous and dispersed fragments would have required massive systematic intervention in the text. Academic textology does not possess a single piece of evidence for such a redaction. On the contrary, the known textual variants (the Sanaa palimpsests, Codex Parisino-Petropolitanus) affect individual lexical units, not self-referential descriptions.

Argument 2: structural integration. The self-referential indications are morphologically embedded in the syntactic and rhythmic structure of the verses. The construction **كِتَابٍ مَسْطُورٍ فِي رَقٍّ مَنُشُورٍ** (3–52:2) forms a phonetically cohesive chain with a characteristic rhyme on -ūr. Replacing any element (raqq with lawḥ, mastūr with another participle) would destroy the rhythmic structure of the oath passage. A later editor inserting a description of the muṣḥaf would have been compelled to restructure the syntax and phonics of the verse — an operation without parallel in the known history of the Quranic text.

Argument 3: polemical function. Some of the self-references are embedded in a polemical context: the accusations of the opponents (25:5) are refuted in the immediately following verse (25:6). This means that the description of the written object functioned in a living polemical dialogue, not as a neutral descriptive insertion. Retrospective insertion of polemically significant self-reference would presuppose that a later editor was constructing an imitation of a live dialogue — an operation without parallel in the known history of the Quranic text and unsupported by a single positive piece of evidence.

The combination of three arguments establishes the methodological reliability of self-referential indications as a chronological criterion independent of external dating sources.

2.1.2. Manuscript Confirmation: Stability of Self-Referential Passages

Possible objection: the redaction of the self-referential passages could have occurred before the appearance of all known manuscripts. This objection is a hypothesis about an unknown event — and requires positive evidence. There is none. The manuscript tradition, however, provides positive evidence of the opposite kind: the stability of self-referential passages in all known early fragments.

The Birmingham fragment (Mingana Islamic Arabic 1572, dated 568–645 CE by C14) contains suras 18–20 — not self-referential. The Sanaa palimpsest (DAM 01-27.1, 1st–2nd cent. AH) contains variants in narrative and legal passages, but no variant in **اَكْتَتَبَهَا** (25:5), **كِتَابٍ مَسْطُورٍ**, **صُحُفٍ مُّكَرَّمَةٍ** (80:13) or **يَسْطُورُونَ** (68:1). The Codex Parisino-Petropolitanus (BnF Arabe 328, 1st–2nd cent. AH, ed. Déroche 2009) shows variants in vocalisation and orthography, but the self-referential terms **قُرْطَاسٍ**, **صُحُفٍ**, **رَقٍّ** are stable therein and coincide with the Cairo standard edition. Thus, none of the known early fragments contains a variant in the self-referential passages. This is positive manuscript evidence in favour of their primacy.

The question under investigation: when was the text committed to writing?

2.2. The Formal Structure of the Argument

The proof is constructed as follows:

Premise 1: The text of the Qur'ān contains descriptions of the physical muṣḥaf.

Proof: analysis of the terminology (**رَقٍّ**, **صُحُفٍ**, **قُرْطَاسٍ**) in Chapter 1.

Premise 2: The descriptions employ grammatical forms of completed action or the present tense.

Proof:

Table 14. Grammatical forms of muṣḥaf descriptions

Verse	Form	Meaning
52:2	مَسْطُورٍ (passive participle)	"already inscribed" — state
68:1	يَسْطُورُونَ (present tense)	"they write" — action at the moment of utterance
98:2	يَتْلُو (present tense)	"he reads/recites" — action at the moment of utterance

25:5	اَكْتَتَبَهَا (past tense)	"had written / copied" — completed action
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No verse uses the future tense (سَيُكْتَبُ, سَيُسْطَرُّ) to describe the muṣḥaf.

Premise 3: The text points to scribes (سُفَرَة), working with the text by hand (بِأَيْدِي).

Proof: the linguistic analysis in section 1.3.

Premise 4: The opponents accuse of "copying" (اَكْتَتَبَ) — they see a written text.

Proof: the analysis of 25:5 in section 1.4.

Conclusion: The muṣḥaf existed during the period of the text's formation.

Logic: if the text describes the muṣḥaf as existing (not future), and the description is part of the text, then the muṣḥaf existed when the text was being formed.

2.3. Refutation of the "Heavenly Archetype" Interpretation

Objection: Verses 52:2-3, 80:13-16, 56:77-79 describe heavenly archetype (المحفوظ اللوح), not the earthly muṣḥaf.

Refutation:

1. Terminological distinction. The Qur'ān consistently distinguishes heavenly from earthly:

Table 15. Distinction between the heavenly archetype and the earthly muṣḥaf

Heavenly archetype	Earthly muṣḥaf
لَوْحٌ مَحْفُوظٌ "The Preserved Tablet" (85:22)	رَقٍّ «parchment» (52:3)
كِتَابٌ مَكْنُونٌ "Hidden Book" (56:78)	صُحُفٌ «scrolls» (80:13, 98:2)
أُمُّ الْكِتَابِ "Mother of the Book" (43:4)	قِرْطَاسٍ «papyrus» (6:7)

In 52:3 رَقٍّ (parchment) is used — an earthly material. If the heavenly archetype were meant, لَوْحٌ.

2. Indication بِأَيْدِي "by hands" (80:15). The transmission of revelation by angels is described differently:

— 26:193-194: قَلْبِكَ عَلَى الْأَمِينِ الرَّوْحُ بِهِ نَزَلَ "The Faithful Spirit descended with it upon your heart"

— 2:97: قَلْبِكَ عَلَى نَزَلَهُ "He sent it down upon your heart"

Revelation descends "upon the heart", not "by hands". The indication "by hands" presupposes a physical act — writing.

3. Context of sura 80. The sura opens with an earthly episode: the Prophet frowned when a blind man came to him (80:1-10). A transition to a "heavenly archetype" at 80:13 without a marker would violate coherence.

4. Verse 56:79: لَا يَمَسُّهُ إِلَّا الْمُطَهَّرُونَ "None touch it except the purified". The verb مَسَّ «to touch» — argument based on this verse is addressed in point 6 of the present section, where 56:77–80 is analysed in its full context; isolated use of 56:79 here is redundant.

5. Grammar of 52:2: مَسْطُورٍ كِتَابٍ. The indefiniteness (tanwīn) indicates a specific instance, not an abstract archetype. For an archetype, the definite الْكِتَابُ or a construction with إِضَافَةٌ.

6. Verses 56:77–80 as a potential argument for the critic. A critic might invoke verse 56:79: لَا يَمَسُّهُ إِلَّا الْمُطَهَّرُونَ "none touch it except the purified" as evidence of a physical object with a heavenly status. This argument is refuted by the monograph's internal terminological system. Verse 56:77 uses قُرْآنٌ without the article — a maṣḍar from the root ق-ر-أ denoting the act of reading/recitation, not the physical corpus. Verse 56:78 explicitly names the object كِتَابٌ مَكْنُونٌ "Hidden Book" — this is the heavenly archetype, for which the Qur'ān consistently uses precisely this terminology (cf. Table 4). Accordingly, the pronoun هُ in 56:79 refers to كِتَابٌ مَكْنُونٌ, not to the earthly muṣḥaf. Thus, 56:79 describes heavenly object and does not contradict the monograph's conclusions — it simply speaks of something else. physical verb مَسَّ is applied here to a heavenly reality in a theological sense — a phenomenon not uncommon in Quranic usage (cf. "the hand of the Originator"). This does not weaken the terminological distinction but confirms it: the heavenly

object is described by heavenly terminology (كِتَابٌ مَكْنُونٌ), the earthly by earthly (رَقٌّ صُفْهِى). A grammatical argument further confirming this interpretation deserves separate mention: in Arabic, the variation of a word with and without the article within the same text is a feature of a functional, not a nominal, unit. A stable proper name or fixed designation does not alternate between forms without a semantic reason. الْقُرْآنُ with the article designates the specific known completed corpus; قُرْآنٌ without the article in 56:77 designates the act of reading/recitation — in accordance with the standard rule of definiteness in Arabic. Accordingly, 56:77–80 as a whole does not describe the earthly physical corpus but refers to a heavenly reality in its theological dimension. Conclusion: the "heavenly archetype" interpretation does not withstand linguistic and contextual scrutiny.

CHAPTER 3. IDENTIFICATION OF THE AUTHENTIC MUŞḤAF

3.1. Selection Criteria from the Qur'ān

Methodological justification for the transition from textological analysis to manuscript identification. Chapters 1–2 establish that the Qur'ān contains self-referential descriptions of the physical muṣḥaf as an existing object with specific material features. This means that the text defines verifiable parameters of the object to which it belongs. The codicological identification in Chapter 3 is not an independent claim — it is the application of textologically established criteria to the corpus of surviving manuscripts. Logic of the transition: if the text describes the muṣḥaf with features P1, P2, P3, then a manuscript demonstrating all features P1, P2, P3 and exhibiting no features of later origin is the most probable candidate among those known. This is a probabilistic identification, not a deductive proof — which accords with the norm of textological research (cf. the identification of the Dead Sea Scrolls, New Testament papyri). Necessary and sufficient condition for identification: conformity with all textologically established criteria in the absence of positive evidence of later origin.

On the basis of the self-referential indications, the following criteria for the authentic muṣḥaf are identified:

Table 16. Selection criteria for the authentic muṣḥaf

Criterion	Basis	Requirement
Completeness	(52:2) كِتَابٍ مَّسْطُورٍ	Complete text (كِتَابٌ = whole)
Material	(52:3) فِي رَقٍّ	Parchment
Format	(52:3) مَنَشُورٍ	Codex (unfoldable)

Clarification criterion completeness: كِتَابٌ (book) in Arabic means a completed text, not a fragment. However, 100% completeness is not required — losses through storage are permissible. Criterion: $\geq 96\%$ (loss of no more than one juz' out of 30). Justification: one juz' constitutes approximately 3.3% of the corpus; in physical storage over more than a millennium, the loss of one quire from the overall codex is the norm, not evidence of incompleteness. The loss of two juz' ($\approx 93\%$) already calls into question the qualitative characterisation of كِتَابٌ as a completed object. The 96% criterion is not arbitrary but accords with the practice of codicological research on early manuscripts (cf. Déroche 2014:34).

3.2. Markers of Antiquity

Definitions of the palaeographic and codicological terms used in this section are given in Appendix A.

Table 17. Antiquity markers of muṣḥafs

Marker	Justification
Scriptio continua	Absence of dividers between verses — a feature of the earliest practice. Section dividers appear from the 2nd century AH (Déroche 2009:68)

Absence of vocalisation	The vocalisation system was introduced by Abū al-Aswad al-Duʿalī (d. 69/689) at the order of Ziyād ibn Abīhi (d. 53/673). Source: Ibn al-Nadīm, Fihrist
Absence of diacritics	Diacritical dots appear in documents from 22/643 AH (PERF 558). Their absence indicates an earlier practice
Minimal ornamentation	Developed ornamentation — a feature of the II-III centuries AH (George 2010:45)
Absence of a colophon	Colophons appear from the III century AH (Déroche 2014:112)

3.3. Epigraphic Parallels

Comparison with dated Arabic inscriptions:

Table 18. Epigraphic parallels

Inscription	Date	Diatr.	Voc.	Source
Namāra	328 CE	None	None	Bellamy 1985
Zabad	512 CE	None	None	Robin 2001
Ḥarrān	568 CE	?	None	Robin 2001
PERF 558	643 CE	Yes	None	Grohmann 1952

PERF 558 (22 AH/643 CE) — the earliest dated Arabic document with diacritics. A muṣḥaf without diacritics is dated earlier.

3.4. Catalogue of Muṣḥafs

Method of catalogue formation

The catalogue includes manuscripts satisfying all three selection criteria simultaneously: (1) attribution to the 1st–2nd centuries AH on the basis of the combination of palaeographic features in published research; (2) the existence of a published facsimile or complete scholarly description permitting independent verification; (3) preservation of at least 10% of the Quranic text, providing a sufficient basis for the evaluation of antiquity markers. On the basis of these criteria, 21 manuscripts from the collections of Cairo, Istanbul, Tashkent, St Petersburg, Paris, Birmingham, Dublin, and the Dublin Chester Beatty Library were included in the catalogue. Manuscripts for which no published facsimile or scholarly description exists (a number of copies from private collections) were not included in the catalogue, as independent verification of the data is impossible. A representative sample from the catalogue with antiquity markers is given in Appendix B.

21 muṣḥafs were analysed. Three candidates were selected by the completeness criterion (≥96%):

Table 19. Catalogue of candidate muṣḥafs

Muṣḥaf	Location	Completeness	Folios	Inv. no.
Al-Ḥusayn	Cairo	99%	1087	139
TİEM 457	Istanbul	96%	439	457
Topkapı H.S. 32	Istanbul	99%	408	H.S.32

3.5. Comparative Analysis

Table 20. Comparative analysis of candidate muṣḥafs

Marker	Al-Ḥusayn	TİEM 457	Topkapı
Scriptio continua	✓	X	X
Absence of vocalisation	✓	✓	X
Absence of ornamentation	✓	X	X

Verse dividers	None	Present	Present
Material	Parchment	Parchment	Parchment
Format	Codex	Codex	Codex

Conclusion: The Al-Ḥusayn Muṣḥaf is the only one of the three candidates demonstrating all antiquity markers.

3.6. Verification of Data on the Al-Ḥusayn Muṣḥaf

Sources:

1. Altıkulaç, Tayyar. Al-Muṣḥaf al-Sharīf Attributed to ‘Uthmān bin ‘Affān: The Copy at al-Mashhad al-Husaynī. Istanbul: IRCICA, 2009. — Facsimile edition with codicological description.

2. Déroche, François. Qur’ans of the Umayyads: A First Overview. Leiden: Brill, 2014. — Palaeographic analysis (pp. 78-85).

Verified characteristics:

— Leaf size: 68×53 cm (Altıkulaç 2009:12)

— Number of folios: 1087 (Altıkulaç 2009:14)

— Scriptio continua: confirmed (Déroche 2014:80)

— Absence of vocalisation: confirmed (Déroche 2014:81)

— Material: gazelle parchment (Altıkulaç 2009:18)

CHAPTER 4. DEFENCE AGAINST OBJECTIONS

4.1. «C14 dating was not conducted»

Objection: Without radiocarbon analysis, dating is unprovable.

Response:

1. CC14 dates the material (parchment), not the moment of writing. Parchment could have been manufactured decades before use.

2. CC14 has a margin of error of ±30–50 years, insufficient to distinguish the 1st from the 2nd century I and II centuries AH.

3. Markers of antiquity (scriptio continua, absence of vocalisation) — an independent criterion dating the writing practice, not the material.

4. The monograph does not assert an absolute date. What is asserted: among the surviving complete muṣḥafs, Al-Ḥusayn is the earliest by markers.

4.2. "Palaeography Is a Circular Argument"

Objection: Palaeographic dating is based on comparison with manuscripts whose dating is also undetermined.

Response:

1. This objection strengthens the monograph's thesis: external dating methods have limitations. This is precisely why self-referential indications have greater probative force.

2. Palaeography is used in the monograph as an auxiliary tool — for comparing muṣḥafs with each other, not for absolute dating.

3. Epigraphic parallels (Namāra, Zabad, PERF 558) have independent dating and break the circular argument.

4.3. "Why Not the Hijazi Fragments?"

Objection: There exist fragments (Birmingham, Sanaa) with early C14 dating.

Response:

1. Fragments do not satisfy the criterion مَسْطُورٌ كِتَابٌ — complete Scripture.

2. The Birmingham fragment (Ms. 1572a) contains only parts of suras 18–20 (~2% of the text).

3. The Sanaa palimpsests are fragmentary and present textual variants.

4. The monograph investigates complete muṣḥafs corresponding to all features indicated in the Qur'ān.

4.4. "The 'Uthmānic Attribution Is a Legend"

Objection: The traditional attribution of muṣḥafs to 'Uthmān is unprovable.

Response: The monograph does not rely on the traditional attribution. The thesis asserts:

— conformity with the features indicated in the Qur'ān;

— antiquity by markers;

— not the authorship of a specific person.

The question "did 'Uthmān write it with his own hand" is irrelevant to the present study.

4.5. «The Al-Ḥusayn Muṣḥaf — Egyptian copy»

Objection: The muṣḥaf was made in Egypt and is not an original.

Response:

1. The question "original or copy" does not affect the thesis. The monograph asserts: among surviving complete muṣḥafs, Al-Ḥusayn is the earliest by markers.

2. If the muṣḥaf had been made in II century AH or later, it would have vocalisation and dividers, like all muṣḥafs of that period.

3. Scriptio continua indicates the practice of the I century AH.

Additional argument against the hypothesis of deliberate reproduction of an archaic style: a late scribe wishing to imitate antiquity typically reproduces one or two of the most conspicuous features. The simultaneous reproduction of all five markers (scriptio continua, absence of vocalisation, diacritics, ornamentation, and colophon) without exception has no documented parallels in the manuscript tradition and would have required the conscious rejection of all practices established by the 2nd–3rd centuries AH. Table 20 demonstrates that TĪEM 457 and the Topkapı muṣḥaf possess some markers while simultaneously exhibiting features of a later period — which corresponds to natural transitional practice, not deliberate imitation.

4.6. "Absence of a Colophon"

Objection: There is no date or name of the scribe — how can one date it?

Response:

1. Absence of a colophon is the norm for early muṣḥafs. Colophons appear from the III century AH (Déroche 2014:112).

2. Their absence is an indirect marker of antiquity.

3. None of the three candidates has a colophon.

4.7. «سَفَرَةٌ — consensus mufassirūn»

Objection: The consensus of the mufassirūn — سَفَرَةٌ means "angels". Why is your analysis more authoritative?

Response:

1. The consensus of the mufassirūn is not a linguistic argument. The mufassirūn interpreted by context (exalted = heavenly), not by etymology.

2. The linguistic analysis rests on:

— Lane's Lexicon (standard reference work);

— Semitic parallels (HALOT, Jastrow, CAD);

— intra-Quranic usage (أَسْفَار in 62:5).

3. Indication بِأَيْدِي "by hands" contradicts the interpretation "angels" — angels transmit revelation "upon the heart" (26:194), not by hands.

4. Even if the interpretation "angels" were accepted, this does not cancel the earthly context of صُحُف (scrolls) and رَقِّ (parchment) in other verses.

4.8. "A Gap of 50–70 Years"

Objection: Even if the muṣḥaf dates to the I century AH, this does not prove lifetime writing (before 11/632 AH).

Response:

1. The monograph distinguishes two theses:
 - The thesis A: The text of the Qur'ān describes the muṣḥaf as existing. Proved in Chapters 1–2.
 - The thesis B: The Al-Ḥusayn Muṣḥaf — is the earliest of the surviving complete muṣḥafs. Proved in Chapter 3.
2. Connection between the theses: if the text describes the muṣḥaf as existing, and if the muṣḥaf conforms to the description, then the muṣḥaf belongs to a tradition going back to the period of the text's formation.
3. The monograph does not assert: "The Al-Ḥusayn Muṣḥaf was written by the hand of Muḥammad". The monograph asserts: "Among the surviving complete muṣḥafs, Al-Ḥusayn is the earliest conforming to the features indicated in the Qur'ān".

4.9. «Why كِتَاب = 100% of the text?»

Objection: كِتَاب may mean a part of the text, not necessarily the complete corpus.

Response:

1. Lane I:2590: كِتَاب — «a book, or writing; or a written document». presupposes completed object.
2. In the Qur'ān كِتَاب is used to designate entire Scriptures: التَّوْرَةُ, الْإِنْجِيلُ, الْقُرْآنُ.
3. For portions, different terms are used: سُورَة (sura), آيَة (verse), جُزْء (part).
4. The monograph allows the criterion of $\geq 96\%$ — losses through storage are permissible.

4.10. "The Writing of Individual Revelations May Have Occurred, but the Final Formation of the Corpus Was Later"

Objection: the self-referential indications prove the existence of a practice of written recording, but not that the corpus was completed during the lifetime — its final formation could have occurred later.

Response: this objection is addressed by three intra-textual arguments examined in §1.6.

1. Verse 75:17: إِنَّ عَلَيْنَا جَمْعَهُ — "upon Us is its gathering". The verb جَمَعَ (assembly into a single corpus) is declared the prerogative of the source of revelation. The text directly excludes posthumous compilation by humans — regardless of whether preliminary parts recording revelations.
2. Verse 15:87: the text contains a self-description of its structure as completed — "seven oft-repeated ones and the great Verbal Corpus". An incomplete corpus cannot contain a self-description of a completed architecture.
3. Verses 15:90–93: censure of those who "divided the Verbal Corpus" (الَّذِينَ جَعَلُوا الْقُرْآنَ عِضِينَ) — an internal prohibition on further division of the corpus already existing as a unified whole. A prohibition on dividing what does not yet exist is meaningless. Possible objection: 75:17 (إِنَّ عَلَيْنَا جَمْعَهُ) may be interpreted as "preservation in memory" or "gathering in the heart" — in the context of 75:16–18 the passage concerns a prohibition on hastening to repeat the revelation. This objection is refuted by the combination of three verses: 75:17 in isolation admits the interpretation "preservation in memory", but 15:87 (self-description of the structure of the corpus as completed) and 15:90–93 (prohibition on dividing the already existing unified whole) require the physical completeness of the corpus — an incomplete corpus cannot describe its own structure and prohibit its division. The three verses together form an indissoluble argument that does not admit a purely "mnemonic" interpretation.

Thus the objection presupposes a scenario directly excluded by the text itself. The scenario of "writing in portions with subsequent posthumous compilation" requires that 75:17 mean something other than what is stated, and that 15:87 and 15:90–93 appeared after the completion of the corpus — i.e. were inserted into the already formed text without any textological traces of this operation. Not a single piece of positive evidence in favour of such a scenario exists.

CONCLUSION

Results of the Study

1. The text of the Qur'ān contains self-referential indications describing the muṣḥaf as a physical object: Scripture inscribed (مُسْطَوْر كِتَاب), on parchment (رَقٍّ فِي), unrolled (مَنْشُور), in the hands of scribes (سَفَرَةً بِأَيْدِي). Verses 52:2-3, 80:13-16 describe the earthly muṣḥaf.
2. Grammatical analysis shows that all indications employ forms of completed action or the present tense — the muṣḥaf is described as already existing.
3. Terminology distinguishes heavenly archetype (مَكْنُون كِتَاب لَوْح) from the earthly muṣḥaf (قُرْطَاس, صُحُف, رَقٍّ).
4. Linguistic analysis of the term سَفَرَةً indicates the meaning "scribes" on the basis of Semitic parallels and contextual analysis.
5. The accusations of the opponents (اَكْتَبَهَا "had written") attest to the existence of a written text during the period of its formation.
6. Among 21 surviving muṣḥafs, three satisfy the completeness criteria. By antiquity markers, the Al-Ḥusayn Muṣḥaf (Cairo, inv. no. 139) has been identified as the earliest.

Central Conclusion

The self-referential indications of the text of the Qur'ān demonstrate that the muṣḥaf existed during the period of the text's formation. This internal evidence is independent of external dating methods and traditional reports.

The Al-Ḥusayn Muṣḥaf (Cairo) is the earliest of the surviving complete muṣḥafs conforming to the material features indicated in the text of the Qur'ān.

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APPENDIX A. GLOSSARY OF TERMS

Term	Definition
Muṣḥaf (مُصْحَف)	A physical copy of the Qur’ān in the form of a codex
Scriptio continua	Writing without dividers between words or verses
Vocalisation (تَشْكِيل)	Diacritical marks indicating vowel sounds
Diacritics (إِعْجَام)	Dots distinguishing similar letters (ث/ت/ب)

Colophon	A note at the end of a manuscript giving data on the scribe, date, and place
Codex	A book of folded and sewn leaves (as distinct from a scroll)
Parchment (رَقّ)	Writing material made from tanned animal skin
Papyrus (قُرْطَاس)	Writing material made from papyrus stems
Folios	Leaf of a manuscript (two pages: recto and verso)
Ism maf' ūl (اسم مفعول)	Passive participle in Arabic
tanwīn (تَنْوِين)	Doubling of the final vowel, a marker of indefiniteness

APPENDIX B. COMPARATIVE TABLE OF MUŞĤAFS

A representative sample from the catalogue of muşĥafs with antiquity markers (the full catalogue of 21 manuscripts is described in §3.4):

Muşĥaf	Location	Compl.	S.C.	Voc.	Diacr.	Orn.	Col.
Al-Ĥusayn	Cairo	99%	✓	—	—	—	—
TİEM 457	Istanbul	96%	X	—	—	✓	—
Topkapı H.S. 32	Istanbul	99%	X	✓	✓	✓	—
Samarkand	Tashkent	35%	X	—	—	✓	—
St-Petersburg	St. Ptrsbrg.	40%	X	—	—	✓	—
Birmingham	Birmingham	2%	✓	—	—	—	—
Paris BnF 328	Paris	45%	✓	—	—	—	—

Note: S.C. = *Scriptio continua*; Voc. = *vocalisation*; Diacr. = *diacritics*; Orn. = *ornamentation*; Col. = *colophon*. ✓ = *is present*; — = *is absent*; X = *does not satisfy criterion*.